



Simplifying The Machine

All you need to know to administer Simple Machines Forum—a free and powerful forum

Mayur Bhatia

Simple Machines Forum (SMF) is probably the easiest forum to install and administer out there. This month, we provide you with tips and secrets to make life easier working with SMF. Before attempting any of these tips, especially the ones that deal with editing specific files, make sure to backup your forum. You can do this through Forum Maintenance Options in your forum administration page or the database program that your forum is running on, like MySQL. For theme-based tweaks, go to your admin page, and navigate to Configuration > Themes and Layout. Scroll down to “Install a new theme” and enter “mytheme” in “Create a copy of default”. Choose this newly-created theme to edit when given a choice to make sure your default themes stay intact.

Now everything is locked and loaded, we can move on.

Install Error?

If you come across the following error when installing Simple Machines Forum—

“Please inform your host that the session.save_path specified in php.ini is not valid! It needs to be changed to a directory that exists, and is writable by the user PHP is running under.”

And if, for some reason, you simply want to get the forum running however possible for the time being, you can use this tip to bypass the session.save_path check.

Note that the forum may not work properly; this tweak is recommended only for experimental reasons. Anyway, here are the instructions:

Go to your SMF install directory, open the install.php file using WordPad and look for the following lines:

```
elseif (session_save_path() == '/tmp' &&
substr(_FILE_, 1, 2) == ':\\')
$error = 'error_session_save_path';
```

Change this code to:

```
if (false)
```

This will make the install skip the session save path check entirely and should allow you to continue the install without errors. The code may vary depending on your SMF version, you can search for “session.save_path” in your text editor to find the code



Delete the highlighted text and put in “if (false)” without the quotes to skip the check for session.save_path

which should be similar to “\$error = ‘error_session_save_path’;”. Replace the code from the place starting from the last ‘elseif’ function. The fix itself (the “if (false)” thingy) should work for all versions.

Use A Billboard

In case you are restoring an older database or making any changes which require you to keep the forum offline, instead of shutting down your entire Web server, you can simply turn on maintenance mode, where users see a message when they try to access any URL within the forum.

You can put the forum in Maintenance Mode by opening the settings.php file in notepad and changing “\$maintenance=0” to “\$maintenance=2”. Editing the message, which users see in Maintenance Mode, can be found further down the file.

Messed-Up Settings?

If any of your core SMF settings turn out messy and prevent you from accessing the forum, instead of restoring your last backup, you can save time by simply downloading repair_settings.php from www.simplemachines.org/download/index.php?thanks;filename=repair_settings.php. This allows you to reset any of your install settings according to your liking. Just place this file in your root SMF folder and access it by using http://your_forum_url/repair_settings.php. Remember to put your

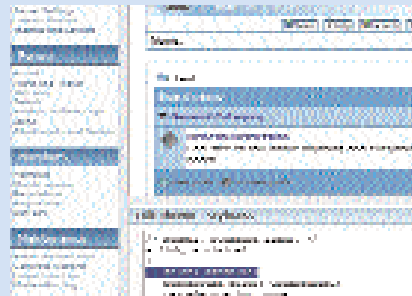
forum in Maintenance Mode and delete this file after you are done working with it, otherwise anyone will have access to it—malicious users will be able to set their own password if they access this URL.

Colour Schemes The Easy Way

Sick of that black text with yellow background used to highlight your search results? Or change any colours for that matter, but don’t want to create an entire theme? Well, head on to themes

and layout in the admin page, click on modify themes and finally click on “modify this theme’s stylesheet”. Notice the weird mixture of numbers and letters next to “color”? These are hex values of your colours, which you can change to your liking. They are sorted in RGB format—FFFFFF represents white, 000000 represents black, FF0000 represents red, 00FF00 represents green, while FFFF00 represents a mix of red and green, and so on.

However, instead of going through



You can put in colour names instead of the hex gibberish

the headache of finding the proper hex value for your colour, you can simply enter in text like “black”, “red” or “blue” or even ‘yellow’ in place of the hex gibberish, experiment and find whether your particular colour text gets accepted.

Your Own Stars

You can add your own GIF images for stars beneath your users’ avatars—just take any image you wish to use and